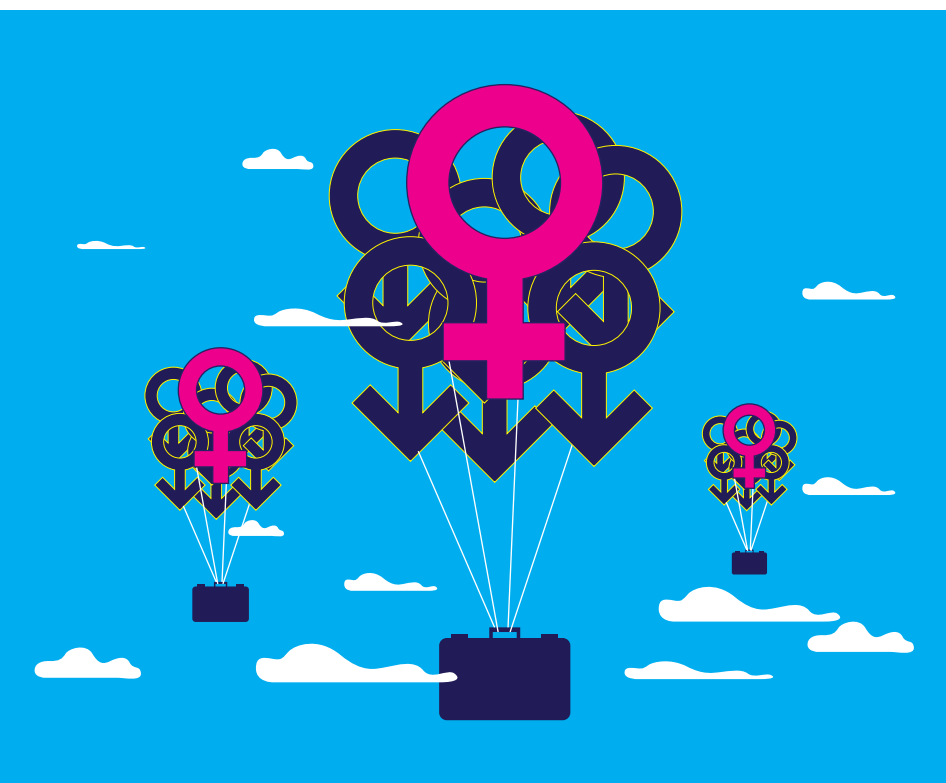




economy, the economic empowerment of women becomes non-negotiable. According to research by the International Labour Organization (ILO), doubling the share of women in the workforce would help raise India's GDP growth rate from 7.5 per cent to 9 per cent. Beyond economic growth, gender equality and women's empowerment are essential to achieving the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Empowering Women to Excel in Leadership Roles: Today, women outnumber men in higher education in India. And yet they lag behind men in corporate leadership. According to a survey by the IBM Institute for Business Value (IBV) and Chief, only 39 per cent of companies in India promoted women to leadership roles, compared to 45 per cent globally.

Diversity is crucial for success

because it adds dimension and perspective, which fosters creative thinking to solve problems. We pride ourselves on being an equal-opportunity employer and aim to have one of the strongest diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) practices in the industry. A third of Biocon's nine-member board are women. In fact, Biocon's performance on board diversity is representative of the broader Indian life sciences sector, which leads all others with the highest percentage of women on boards at 24 per cent.

Over four-and-a-half decades of leadership have taught me that women's intrinsic emotional intelligence allows them to empathise and connect with others. Their compassion, sensitivity, and multitasking abilities help them solve problems with a clear head. Moreover, women are good team players and more democratic as team leaders.

A Diverse Boardroom is the Key to Success:

Numerous studies have indicated that companies with more women on their boards and top leaders are more profitable. Gender-diverse boards may lead cultural transformations that help organisations negotiate the current volatile, uncertain, complex, and ambiguous landscape beyond financial success. They can influence how corporations respond to global challenges, navigate macro and geopolitical shifts, adapt to new regulations and address heightened scrutiny of climate change and ESG-related initiatives.

To realise this transformative potential, corporate entities in India must proactively formulate comprehensive gender diversity strategies, promoting an inclusive environment that facilitates equal participation at all organisational levels. This necessitates initiatives to attract and retain talented women, ensure equitable compensation, and cultivate a robust pipeline of female talent, ultimately contributing to a more balanced representation on corporate boards.

Simultaneously, women leaders must embrace their rights, articulating and registering their perspectives while cultivating unwavering confidence in their competence and leadership acumen. Championing their place in senior leadership and boardroom roles requires not only individual assertion but also a commitment to mentorship, promoting other women to senior positions and nurturing a broader pool of talent poised for board positions.

In the pursuit of a more inclusive corporate landscape, collaboration and empowerment can pave the way for sustained success and innovation on a global scale. **BT**

Views are personal